

Rare Rain Brings Bright Flowers to Chile's Atacama Desert

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Bright **wildflowers** are growing across Chile's Atacama Desert after rare rain. The rain is linked to this year's very strong El Niño. A report published on October 2, 2026, describes flowers spreading across hills and flat land in one of Earth's driest places.

The rain helped millions of seeds and **bulbs** start growing. **Bulbs** are plant parts that grow underground. Seeds and **bulbs** can rest underground for years until enough water arrives. Land that usually has few plants is now covered with purple, pink, white, red and yellow flowers.

In Chile, people call this event "desierto florido." This means "flowering desert." Jorge Carabantes leads the Protected Areas Department at Chile's National Forest Corp., also called CONAF. He told The Associated Press that more than 200 plant **species**, or kinds of plants, are part of the **bloom**. He said this desert flowering is unusual and different from **blooms** elsewhere.

The Atacama usually gets only 0.6 inches, or 15 millimeters, of rain each year. Between July and August 2026, several regions in Chile had record **rainfall**. Carabantes said some areas got more than 190 millimeters. Some regions had not seen that much rain since the 1950s. These numbers describe several Chilean regions. They are not one rain measurement for the whole desert.

The flowers cover about 6,560 square miles, or 17,000 square kilometers. CONAF representatives told The Associated Press that this is the Atacama's largest **bloom** since 1997.

Tourists and photographers have come to see the flowers against the mountains. Photos show cacti among the flowers and purple flowers across the flat land.

The flowers will not stay all year. Many will disappear by the end of spring in the **Southern Hemisphere**, the southern half of Earth. They will leave seeds and **bulbs** underground. These can wait for another time when unusually heavy rain arrives.

Word Treasure

wildflowers -- Flowers that grow in nature.

bulbs -- Plant parts that grow underground and can begin growing when enough water arrives.

species -- Different kinds of living things; here, different kinds of plants.

bloom -- A time when plants produce flowers.

rainfall -- The amount of rain that falls in an area.

Southern Hemisphere -- The southern half of Earth.

Break it down

Opening: Rare rain linked to a very strong El Niño brings flowers to the Atacama Desert.

How it happens: Water helps resting seeds and bulbs grow.

Expert information: Jorge Carabantes explains the name of the event and the number of plant species.

Size and rainfall: Measurements show how unusual the rain and bloom are, with a reminder that regional rainfall figures do not describe the whole desert.

Ending: Visitors enjoy the flowers before many disappear and leave seeds and bulbs underground.

Why it matters

The bloom shows how rain can change a very dry place and help plants that have waited underground for years begin growing.

Test what you remember

1. Where are the bright wildflowers growing?

- ☐ (A) In an underground cave
- ☐ (B) On a snowy island
- ☐ (C) Across Chile's Atacama Desert
- ☐ (D) Only inside a greenhouse

2. What helped the resting seeds and bulbs start growing?

- ☐ (A) Mountain shadows
- ☐ (B) Rain
- ☐ (C) Dry winds blowing across the land
- ☐ (D) Photographers

3. What does "desierto florido" mean?

- ☐ (A) Purple mountain
- ☐ (B) Flowering desert
- ☐ (C) The southern half of Earth
- ☐ (D) A place with no rain

4. According to Jorge Carabantes, how many plant species are part of the bloom?

- ☐ (A) Exactly five
- ☐ (B) About fifty
- ☐ (C) Fewer than fifteen
- ☐ (D) More than 200

5. What do the rainfall numbers for July and August 2026 describe?

- ☐ (A) Every desert on Earth
- ☐ (B) One measurement for the whole desert
- ☐ (C) Several regions in Chile
- ☐ (D) Only the rain that fell on one flower

6. What will many flowers leave behind when they disappear?

- ☐ (A) Seeds and bulbs that can wait underground
- ☐ (B) Rain clouds
- ☐ (C) New mountains
- ☐ (D) Photographs of cacti

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Jorge Carabantes:** He describes the flowering as unusual and says it includes more than 200 plant species.
2. **CONAF representatives:** They say this is the Atacama's largest bloom since 1997.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):